ferent protests with different politics, but they are connected by a growing suspicion among young Indians that the gateways to education, jobs and upward mobility are neither predictable nor fair.

That anxiety is most clearly visible in answers to the question about the state of democracy. In January 2026, 46 per cent of respondents said democracy was not in danger, compared with 44.7 per cent who believed it was. Seven months later, the positions have reversed: 46.7 per cent now believe democracy is in danger, while 41.6 per cent say it is not. This is not the first time the 'danger' figure has exceeded the 'not in danger' figure. It also happened in August 2025 and in several earlier surveys. But the improvement recorded in January has now all but disappeared.

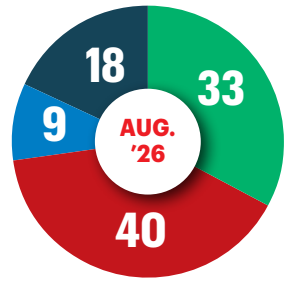
More worrying is the steady erosion in confidence that elections are free and fair. A year ago, in August 2025, 64.4 per cent of respondents said they were. That fell to 56.5 per cent in January and has now dropped to 51.9 per cent. Over the same period, the share of those who believe elections are not free and fair has risen from 31.7 per cent to 40.9 per cent. This is perhaps the most significant institutional warning in these findings.

And yet voters are not buying every argument made against the Election Commission. Asked directly about trust in the EC over the past year, 43.3 per cent say it has increased and 38 per cent state the opposite. On the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, an emphatic 60.2 per cent believe the exercise was necessary to remove bogus or duplicate voters. The message is clear: voters can worry about electoral fairness without accepting the Opposition's entire narrative.

There is another notable reversal: over the misuse of enforcement agencies. In January, 47.7 per cent said governments of all political parties misuse agencies such as the Enforcement Directorate (ED), Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and Income Tax Department; 41.1 per cent specifically accused the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government of doing so. Now the order has flipped: the BJP-specific figure has risen to 43.8 per cent; the other has fallen to 38.1 per cent.

At the same time, 54.1 per cent still say they feel free to express themselves on politics and religion, though that is down from 57.3 per cent in January. The picture, therefore, is not of a frightened society that believes it cannot speak, but of one becoming uneasy about how power is exercised.

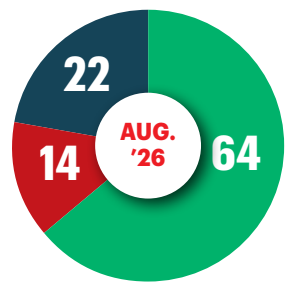
Q. Should the next delimitation of parliamentary constituencies be based only on population, or should states that successfully controlled population growth also be protected from losing representation?



Seats should be based mainly on current population | Population control performance should also be considered | The present distribution should continue | DK/ CS

On delimitation, the biggest cohort favours protecting states that controlled population

Q. Should India strengthen its anti-defection law to make it harder for elected representatives to switch political allegiance after an election?



Yes | No | DK/ CS

Nearly two-thirds want a stronger anti-defection law

All figures in % and rounded off; DK/ CS: Don't know/ can't say

FAITH FACTOR

The Ram Mandir donation theft shows how quickly a governance failure could damage a cornerstone of the BJP's considerable social capital. Asked about the reported theft of offerings at Ayodhya, 46.6 per cent say it has negatively affected their view of both the Modi and Yogi Adityanath gov-



VOTERS' VOICE People show their inked fingers after voting, Kolkata, Apr. 29

ANI